

Course Information

Course Number: POLS 318
Course Title: Theories of International Relations
Section:
Time: T/R 4:25pm-5:40pm
Location: ALLN 1003
Credit Hours: 3

Instructor Details

Instructor: Devin P. Brown
Office: ALLN 3107
E-Mail: devinpbrown@tamu.edu
Office Hours: T/R 3:00pm-4:00pm, or by appointment

Course Description

Examination of major paradigms of international relations; focus on theory development and application to cases.

Why does war occur? Why do states so often fail to solve disputes peacefully? How do states interact in times of peace? In this class, we will examine answers to these questions through a survey of major theories of international relations. The first half of the course will trace the development of the three major paradigms (realism, liberalism, and constructivism). The second half surveys newer developments in international relations covering the democratic peace, the role of domestic politics in international conflict, “new” warfare, terrorism, and human rights.

Course Prerequisites

POLS 206, POLS 209, and junior or senior classification or approval of department head.

Course Learning Outcomes

- Explain the core assumptions, key concepts, and causal arguments of the major paradigms in international relations theory.
- Compare and contrast the assumptions and arguments of the major paradigms.
- Use the paradigms to understand real-world phenomena.

Textbook and/or Resource Materials

There is no *required* textbook for this course. All required readings will be uploaded to Canvas.

Our readings draw heavily on the following books, if you want to purchase a copy. PDF copies of the assigned portions will be made available on Canvas.

Baylis, John and Steve Smith and Patricia Owens. 2023. *The Globalization of World Politics: An Introduction to International Relations*. 9th Edition. Oxford University Press.

Williams, Phil and Donald M. Goldstein and Jay M. Shafritz. 1994. *Classic Readings of International Relations*. International Thomson Publishing.

Grading Policy

- A = 89.5 – 100 B = 79.5 – 89.4 C = 69.5 – 79.4 D = 59.5 – 69.4 F = 59.4 and below
- Every day, students will be expected to turn in a short (2-5 sentences) reflection about the day's topic. Reflections will receive a simple pass/ fail based on the quality of the reflection. See section on Daily Reflections for more assignment details.
- Students are expected to complete assigned readings *before* class.
- There will be 5 quizzes spread throughout the semester. These will consist of multiple choice, true/false, and one essay question. The quizzes will only cover "new" content (anything covered since the most recent quiz). They are not cumulative.
- There will be two exams: a **cumulative midterm exam** at the beginning of the eighth (8th) week of class and a **cumulative final exam** at the end of the semester. The exams will consist of multiple choice, true/ false, and short answer questions. There will also be 2-4 handwritten short essay questions on each exam.

Assignment	Total Grade Percentage
Daily Reflections	30%
Quizzes (5)	30% 6% for each quiz
Midterm	20%
Final Exam	20%

- The automatic grade calculation in Canvas will miscalculate your *final/ cumulative grade*; however, the percentages are correct within each assignment category. I calculate your final grade using the following formula, corresponding to the grade breakdown above:

$$0.3 * (\text{Daily Reflection Grade \%}) + 0.3 * (\text{Quiz Grade \%}) + 0.2 * (\text{Midterm}) + 0.2 * (\text{Final})$$

Daily Reflections

Instead of taking attendance, every day, I will collect daily reflections from everyone in the class. This will serve as your attendance grade.

Daily reflections are a way for me to make sure you come to class and that you are engaging with the material. Good reflections should pose a new question, draw a connection between the day's content and previous classes, highlight some tension between theory and reality, or outline a key takeaway from

the class as it relates to modern events. You may also use the reflection to talk about things you don't quite understand yet or discussions that confused you. In all cases, you should elaborate on your thoughts/ questions and reference **specific** concepts and discussions from class.

Examples of unacceptable reflections:

"I'm unclear about what power means."

"Today I learned about realism. I didn't know about that before."

"Today we talked about the variants of liberalism. I think republican liberalism is the best one."

Examples of acceptable reflections:

"I was unclear about what constitutes soft power. Most of our discussions focused on popular media, but I was unclear about how movies can have such an impact on politics."

"I really disagree with some of the ideas of liberalism. I don't think that governments would join international organizations if there wasn't some tangible benefit to doing so. And once an agreement becomes too costly, states drop out. Realism can account for both of these dynamics much better than Liberalism, in my opinion."

"After our discussion on the sources of cooperation, I'm confused as to why anyone goes to war. Since most of the time states have repeated interactions, shouldn't everyone eventually figure out how to cooperate?"

Acceptable reflections will receive 1 point. Unacceptable reflections will receive a half point. Reflections cannot be made up for unexcused absences.

Daily Reflections and Quiz Make-Up Policy

- For Daily Reflections (regular class days):
 - Daily reflections must be submitted in person at the end of each class
 - If you have an excused absence (student rule 7), I will excuse your daily reflection. That day will not contribute to your overall daily reflection grade.
 - If your absence is not excused, you will receive a zero for the daily reflection. You cannot make up a daily reflection if you have an unexcused absence.
- For Quiz and Exam Days:
 - If you know that you will be absent on the day of a quiz (excused or not), let me know ahead of time and try to arrange a time to take the quiz before the scheduled time.
 - For day-of emergencies, notify me ASAP that you will miss the quiz.
 - You must provide a doctor's note (or other official documentation) in order to make up the quiz.
 - You must arrange a time with me to make up the quiz within one week of the end of your sickness, according to the date on your doctor's note.
 - Unexcused absences on the day of a quiz will result in a 0 on the quiz.

Course Schedule

W1 – Day 1 (08/25): Introduction, Syllabus, Foundations

W1 – Day 2 (08/27): Realism 1

- BSO. Ch. 9 “Realism” p. 132-146.

W2 -Day 1 (09/01): Realism 2

- Classic Readings p. 24-47. (Realism)

W2- Day 2 (09/03): **Professor Brown at Conference – No Class**

W3 – Day 1 (09/08): Realism 3

- Classic Readings p. 190-209 (Anarchy, Conflict, Security Dilemma)

W3 – Day 2 (09/10): Realism 4

- Classic Readings p. 57-71 (Polarity)

W4 – Day 1 (09/15): **Quiz 1 Realism**

W4 – Day 2 (09/17): Liberalism 1

- BSO. Ch. 7 “Liberal Internationalism” p. 103-115

W5 – Day 1 (09/22) Liberalism 2

- Moravcsik, Andrew. 1997. “Taking Preferences Seriously: A Liberal Theory of International Politics.” *International Organization* 51 (4): 513-53.

W5 – Day 2 (09/24) Liberalism 3

W6 – Day 1 (09/29): **Quiz 2 Liberalism**

W6 – Day 2 (10/01): Constructivism 1

- BSO. Ch 13. “Social Constructivism” p. 194-212.

W7 – Day 1 (10/06): Constructivism 2

- Wendt, Alexander. 1992. “Anarchy Is What States Make of It: The Social Construction of Power Politics.” *International Organization* 46 (2): 391-425.

W7 – Day 2 (10/08): Constructivism 3

W8 - Day 1 (10/13): **Quiz 3 Constructivism**

W8 – Day 2 (10/15): Midterm Exam Review

W9 – Day 1 (10/20): **Midterm Exam**

W9 – Day 2 (10/22): Selectorate Theory

- Bueno de Mesquita, Bruce, James D. Morrow, Randolph M. Siverson, and Alastair Smith. 1999. “An Institutional Explanation of the Democratic Peace.” *American Political Science Review* 93 (4): 791-807.

W10 – Day 1 (10/27): Explaining Peace: Democratic Peace Theory

- Layne, Christopher. 1994. “Kant or Can’t: The Myth of the Democratic Peace.” *International Security* 19(2): 5-49.

W10 – Day 2 (10/29): Reaction: Capitalist Peace Theory

- Gartzke, Erik. 2007. “The Capitalist Peace.” *American Journal of Political Science* 51 (1): 166-91.

W11 – Day 1 (11/03): Democratic Peace Review/ Catch-Up

W11 – Day 2 (11/05): **Quiz 4** Substitute Proctor - Professor Brown at Conference

W12 – Day 1 (11/10): Conflict Bargaining 1

- Fearon, James. 1995. "Rationalist Explanations for War." *International Organization* 49(3): 379-414.

W12 – Day 2 (11/12): Conflict Bargaining 2

- Fearon, James D. 1994. "Domestic Political Audiences and the Escalation of International Disputes." *American Political Science Review* 88 (3): 577-92.

W13 – Day 1 (11/17): Conflict Bargaining 3

- Weeks, Jessica. 2008. "Autocratic Audience Costs: Regime Type and Signaling Resolve." *International Organization* 62(1): 35-64.

W13 – Day 2 (11/19): Conflict Bargaining Review/ Catch-Up

W14 – Day 1 (11/24): **Quiz 5**

W14 – Day 2 (11/26): **Give Thanks – No Class**

W15 – Day 1 (12/1): **Redefined Day – Go to your Friday Class**

W15 – Day 2 (12/3): Final Exam Review

- Come prepared with questions and study materials!

Final Exam at 1:00 PM on Wednesday December 9th in our regular meeting place (ALLN 1003)

Attendance Policy

The university views class attendance and participation as an individual student responsibility. Students are expected to attend class and to complete all assignments.

Please refer to [Student Rule 7](#) in its entirety for information about excused absences, including definitions, and related documentation and timelines.

Makeup Work Policy

Students will be excused from attending class on the day of a graded activity or when attendance contributes to a student's grade, for the reasons stated in Student Rule 7, or other reason deemed appropriate by the instructor.

Please refer to [Student Rule 7](#) in its entirety for information about makeup work, including definitions, and related documentation and timelines.

Absences related to Title IX of the Education Amendments of 1972 may necessitate a period of more than 30 days for make-up work, and the timeframe for make-up work should be agreed upon by the student and instructor" ([Student Rule 7, Section 7.4.1](#)).

“The instructor is under no obligation to provide an opportunity for the student to make up work missed because of an unexcused absence” ([Student Rule 7, Section 7.4.2](#)).

Students who request an excused absence are expected to uphold the Aggie Honor Code and Student Conduct Code. (See [Student Rule 24](#).)

Academic Integrity Statement and Policy

“An Aggie does not lie, cheat or steal, or tolerate those who do.”

“Texas A&M University students are responsible for authenticating all work submitted to an instructor. If asked, students must be able to produce proof that the item submitted is indeed the work of that student. Students must keep appropriate records at all times. The inability to authenticate one’s work, should the instructor request it, may be sufficient grounds to initiate an academic misconduct case” ([Section 20.1.2.3, Student Rule 20](#)).

You can learn more about the Aggie Honor System Office Rules and Procedures, academic integrity, and your rights and responsibilities at aggiehonor.tamu.edu.

Notice of Nondiscrimination

Texas A&M University is committed to providing safe and non-discriminatory learning, living, and work environments for all members of the University community. The University provides equal opportunity to all employees, students, applicants for employment or admission, and the public regardless of race, color, sex (including pregnancy and related conditions), religion, national origin, age, disability, genetic information, or veteran status. Texas A&M University will promptly, thoroughly, and fairly investigate and resolve all complaints of discrimination, harassment (including sexual harassment), complicity and related retaliation based on a protected class in accordance with System Regulation 08.01.01, University Rule 08.01.01.M1, Standard Administrative Procedure (SAP) 08.01.01.M1.01, and applicable federal and state laws. In accordance with Title IX and its implementing regulations, Texas A&M does not discriminate on the basis of sex in any educational program or activity, including admissions and employment. The following person has been designated to handle inquiries and complaints regarding the non-discrimination policies: Jennifer M. Smith, TAMU Associate VP & Title IX Coordinator at YMCA Ste 108, College Station, TX 77843, 979-458-8407, or email civilrights@tamu.edu. For other reporting options, visit <https://ocrcas.ed.gov/contact-ocr> to locate the address and phone number of the office that serves your area, or call 1-800-421-3481.

Civil Rights, Free Speech, and Title IX Policies

Texas A&M University is committed to fostering a learning environment that is safe and productive for all. University policies and federal and state laws prohibit discrimination and harassment based on an individual’s race, color, sex, (including pregnancy and related conditions), religion, national origin, age, disability, genetic information, veteran status, or any other legally protected characteristic. This includes

forms of sex-based violence, such as sexual assault, sexual harassment, sexual exploitation, dating/domestic violence, and stalking.

Students can report discrimination/harassment, access supportive resources, or learn more about their options for resolving complaints on the [University's Civil Rights & Title IX webpage](#).

Students should be aware that all university employees (except medical or mental health providers) are mandatory reporters, which means that if they observe, experience or become aware of an incident that they reasonably believe to be discrimination/harassment alleged to have been committed by or against a person who was a student or employee at the time of the incident, the employee must report the incident to the university.

Americans with Disabilities Act (ADA) Policy

Texas A&M University is committed to providing equitable access to learning opportunities for all students. If you experience barriers to your education due to a disability or think you may have a disability, please contact the Disability Resources office on your campus (resources listed below). Disabilities may include, but are not limited to attentional, learning, mental health, sensory, physical, or chronic health conditions. All students are encouraged to discuss their disability related needs with Disability Resources and their instructors as soon as possible.

To request academic accommodations, contact the designated ADA office based on your location:

- Texas A&M University, College of Nursing, College of Dentistry, Irma Lerma Rangel College of Pharmacy College Station, College of Medicine, School of Public Health, Institute of Biosciences and Technology, EnMed Program, Bush School in Washington DC, Mays Business School – CityCentre, TAMU Engineering Academies, Texas A&M University Higher Education Center at McAllen and Texas A&M University at Galveston should contact [Disability Resources](#) at (979) 845-1637 or disability@tamu.edu.
- Texas A&M University School of Law should contact the Office of Student Affairs at (817) 212-4111 or law-disability@law.tamu.edu to request accommodations.
- Irma Lerma Rangel College of Pharmacy in Kingsville should contact the Disability Resource Center at Texas A&M University - Kingsville at (361) 593-3024 or drc.center@tamuk.edu to request accommodations.
- Texas A&M University College of Veterinary Medicine & Biomedical Sciences in Canyon should contact the Office of Student Accessibility at West Texas A&M University – Canyon at (806) 651-2335 or osa@wtamu.edu.
- Texas A&M University at Qatar (TAMUQ) should contact the campus psychologist, Dr. Steve Wilson +974-4423-0047 or stephen.wilson@qatar.tamu.edu.

If you are experiencing difficulties with your approved accommodations, contact the office responsible for approving your accommodations or the Texas A&M ADA Coordinator Julie Kuder at ADA.Coordinator@tamu.edu or (979) 458-8407.

Pregnancy Accommodations

Texas A&M provides reasonable accommodations to students due to pregnancy and/or related conditions, such as childbirth, recovery and lactation. Students should contact the University's [Pregnancy Coordinator](#) as soon as they become aware of the need for accommodation. Depending on the circumstances, accommodations could include extended time to complete assignments or exams, changes in course sequence, or modifications to the physical classroom environment. Texas A&M will also allow a voluntary leave of absence, ensure the availability of lactation space, and maintain grievance procedures to provide for the prompt and equitable resolution of complaints of sex discrimination. For information regarding pregnancy accommodations, email TIX.Pregnancy@tamu.edu.

Statement on Mental Health and Wellness

Texas A&M University recognizes that mental health and wellness are critical factors influencing a student's academic success and overall wellbeing. Students are encouraged to engage in healthy self-care practices by utilizing the resources and services available through [University Health Services](#). Students needing a listening ear can call the Texas A&M Helpline (979.845.2700) from 4:00 p.m. to 8:00 a.m. weekdays and 24 hours on weekends for mental health peer support while classes are in session. The [TELUS Health Student Support app](#) provides access to professional counseling in multiple languages anytime, anywhere by phone or chat, and the 988 Suicide & Crisis Lifeline offers 24-hour emergency support at 988 or 988lifeline.org.

Students needing a listening ear can contact University Health Services (979.458.4584) or call the Texas A&M Helpline (979.845.2700) from 4:00 p.m. to 8:00 a.m. weekdays and 24 hours on weekends while classes are in session. 24-hour emergency help is also available through the 988 Suicide & Crisis Lifeline (988) or at 988lifeline.org.

Statement on the Family Educational Rights and Privacy Act (FERPA)

FERPA is a federal law designed to protect the privacy of educational records by limiting access to these records, to establish the right of students to inspect and review their educational records and to provide guidelines for the correction of inaccurate and misleading data through informal and formal hearings. Currently enrolled students wishing to withhold any or all directory information items can do so within howdy.tamu.edu using the Directory Information Withholding Form. The complete [FERPA Notice to Students](#) and the student records policy is available on the Office of the Registrar webpage.

Items that can never be identified as public information are a student's social security number, citizenship, gender, grades, GPR or class schedule. All efforts will be made in this class to protect your privacy and to ensure confidential treatment of information associated with or generated by your participation in the class.

Directory items include name, UIN, local address, permanent address, email address, local telephone number, permanent telephone number, dates of attendance, program of study (college, major, campus), classification, previous institutions attended, degrees honors and awards received,

participation in officially recognized activities and sports, medical residence location and medical residence specialization.

Statement on AI Use

According to the Texas A&M University Definitions of Academic Misconduct, plagiarism is the appropriation of another person's ideas, processes, results or words without giving appropriate credit (aggiehonors.tamu.edu). You should credit your use of anyone else's words, graphic images, or ideas using standard citation styles. Artificial Intelligence (AI) text generators and natural language processing tools (colloquially, chatbots - such as ChatGPT), audio, computer code, video, and image generators should not be used for any work for this class without explicit permission of the instructor and appropriate attribution. This includes, but is not limited to,

- i. Creating or revising drafts
- ii. Editing your work
- iii. Reviewing a peer's work

This excludes pre-existing software additions such as spelling and grammar checkers, which are acceptable.